

What the Phones Taught Me

*Lessons from Three Months as a Company's First SDR,
Calling Into a World I Didn't Come From*

Bryce Lote

Sales Development Representative, Calvient

May 2026

*Sometimes we have to take a step back to spring
forward.*

The Starting Line

I started at Calvient in March 2026. First SDR the company ever hired. Twelve employees. No playbook written by someone who had done the job before me. A CRM full of potential. A phone. And a market I had never worked in.

Calvient builds AI-powered workflow automation for healthcare organizations. Referral tracking, prior authorizations, fax intake, document processing. The kind of work that keeps the lights on inside a clinic but rarely makes it into a headline. My territory was Federally Qualified Health Centers, FQHCs, the community health organizations that serve patients regardless of ability to pay. Majority Medicaid. Governed by federal compliance standards. Staffed by people who didn't stay for the salary.

I didn't come from healthcare. My mother was a NICU charge nurse for forty years and my father spent his career in IT and cybersecurity, so I grew up around both worlds. But I had never sold into them. My sales background was consultative, relationship-driven, built in fitness and small business operations. I knew how to close. I knew how to build systems. I did not know what a referral coordinator's Wednesday looked like.

That was the gap. And everything I learned in three months came from trying to close it.

The Playbook I Was Given

My onboarding was structured the way most SDR ramps are. Learn the product. Learn the ICP. Learn the scripts. Hit the phones.

The scripts were solid. They asked the right questions. *"How are you currently handling inbound referrals?" "What EHR are you on?" "How many people usually touch those?"* The sequences were built with a familiar logic: call, voicemail, email, wait, call again, email again, breakup.

I followed the playbook. I hit the activity numbers. And within the first few weeks, something started to feel off.

Not broken. Just insufficient.

The scripts got me into conversations. But the conversations I was having didn't sound like the scripts I was reading. The people on the other end of the phone were not talking about "referral leakage" or "care coordination platforms." They were saying things like *"we just never hear back"* and *"I have to call the specialist office and sit on hold and sometimes they hang up and I call back."* One coordinator told me she had over a thousand open referrals in her queue and was having a very difficult time keeping up.

Nobody had written a script for that.

The First Real Conversation

The call that changed how I thought about this job was with a woman named Genevieve at a community health center in south Texas.

I called the referral department. She answered. I asked a simple question: "*How do you guys keep track of referrals when they're sent out to a specialist?*"

She talked for several minutes. Unprompted. She described the entire workflow. Send the referral, call the specialist within a week, check on scheduling, wait until after the appointment, request notes via fax, attach them in the EHR, assign back to the provider. She told me three specialists cover fifteen providers. She told me the GI department was scheduling patients into February of the following year. She told me providers mark things urgent while specialists disagree and push them down the list.

I didn't ask for any of that. I just asked about the work.

And then she offered to connect me with her supervisor. She gave me the supervisor's email and the department fax number. All unprompted. Not because I pitched well. Because nobody had asked her about her job before. At least not like that. Not with curiosity instead of a clipboard.

That call taught me the first real lesson of outbound sales in this space: the people closest to the problem will tell you everything if you ask about the work instead of the org chart.

What My Emails Actually Sounded Like

A few weeks in, I looked back at the emails I had been sending. The templates were clean. Professional. They asked reasonable questions. But reading them through the eyes of someone who receives six vendor emails a week, they all looked the same.

My first sequence asked the same question three times in slightly different words across three emails. *"How are you tracking referral completion?"* Then: *"I realized my last email was a bit broad, so I'll ask it more directly."* Then: *"Should I be asking someone else?"*

Three versions of the same question over two weeks. If someone didn't respond to the first one, it wasn't because the question was unclear. It was because they had no reason to give a stranger their time. Repeating the question in different words doesn't create a new reason. It creates fatigue.

The second email was worse than the first because it apologized for it. *"I realized my last email was a bit broad"* told the reader that I knew my first email wasn't good enough. That doesn't build confidence. It signals that I'm unsure of what I'm doing. And the "direct" version was the same question anyway.

The breakup email, *"Should I be asking someone else?"*, got opens. But it got them through a small anxiety. The reader wonders for a second if someone on their team has been talking to you. Then they open it and find the same question for the third time. The open was earned through a pressure tactic. Not through value.

I had to rebuild the whole approach.

The Rebuild

The framework I landed on was simple in concept and hard in practice.

Touch one is a mirror. An observation about the reader's world that demonstrates you've listened to people like them. Not a question. Not a pitch. A sentence or two that describes a reality they recognize.

Touch two is a window. A peer story. Something specific from a real conversation with someone at another organization. Not a data point. A person. A moment. Something the reader can picture happening in their own building.

Touch three is an invitation. The first ask in the entire sequence. Small. Human. One question they can answer in a sentence.

Each touch gives the reader something the previous touch didn't. And the absence of an ask in touches one and two is the thing that separates you from every other vendor in the inbox.

That last part was the hardest to trust. Every instinct in sales says make the ask. Get the meeting. Move the deal forward. Withholding the CTA felt like leaving money on the table. But what it actually did was let the relationship breathe. It let the reader experience three contacts with me before I ever asked for anything. By the time I did ask, I wasn't a stranger. I was someone who had been paying attention.

The Email That Proved It

The conversation that validated the whole approach was with a nursing director named Miriam at a center in south Texas. I sent a cold email. Short. Three sentences. Mentioned Calvient. Asked a low-friction question with two options: connect before a conference or catch up there.

She replied warmly. Over the next two days we exchanged several emails. But the structure of those emails was the thing that mattered.

I narrowed before expanding. Instead of asking broad questions, I offered two categories, referrals versus prior authorizations, and asked which was more relevant. She picked. Then I asked within that category: workload reduction or completion consistency? She said both. Each question was a fork that let her direct the conversation.

I validated before advancing. When she described her situation, I reflected it back before introducing new information. She knew she was being heard. Not sold to.

And Miriam disclosed voluntarily. She shared that she was thirty days into the role, that they had an active pilot, that her social services team was overwhelmed, that she had doubts about patient self-scheduling for her population. She told me *"the nurse in me can't help but care."* None of that was extracted. It was offered because the conversation felt safe.

That exchange became the anchor story for my entire FQHC outreach. Not because it was a closed deal. Because it captured the tension that every operations leader in this space carries: the pull between reducing staff burden and making sure vulnerable patients don't fall through the cracks. That tension is structural. It is the thing that makes this market different from anything I had sold into before. And I only understood it because Miriam trusted me enough to describe it.

The Ground-Level Strategy

Somewhere around week four, I started calling into organizations differently.

The standard approach was to go straight to the decision maker. COO. VP of Operations. Director of Clinical Operations. Send an email. Leave a voicemail. Follow up. Follow up again. Hope.

I started calling the referral department first instead.

Not to pitch. Not to get transferred. Just to learn. I would ask a referral coordinator one question about how they track follow-up and let the conversation go wherever it went. And those conversations taught me more about the organization in ten minutes than an hour of web research could.

I learned that most centers track referrals manually. No automated alerts. No system flags. Staff use memory, assigned date ranges, or spreadsheets alongside the EHR. I learned that the bottleneck is almost never inside the building. It's the specialist office not responding, not scheduling, not sending notes back. I learned that follow-up involves repeated phone calls and faxes, three attempts documented, then a letter, then close it out. I learned that the three-attempt protocol protects the organization legally but doesn't protect the patient. The coordinator follows the protocol. The referral gets closed. But the patient who didn't answer three calls from an unknown number still hasn't seen the specialist.

Compliance was met. Care wasn't.

I would never have known any of that if I had only talked to COOs.

And then something unexpected happened. When I did reach the decision maker, the conversation was different. Because I wasn't guessing what their problems were. I had heard them described in detail by the people living them. I could name a reality and ask the decision maker to confirm or deny it. That's a

peer-level exchange. Not an audit.

One coordinator at a center in south Florida had built an entire tracking infrastructure herself. She got her team portal access to six hospital systems. She maintained a spreadsheet tracking who has access to what. She trained her coordinators on a drag-and-drop workflow instead of print-and-scan. She built all of it from the ground up because nobody gave her a system that did it. That's operational innovation happening at the coordinator level without anyone above them realizing it was never supposed to be their job.

When I eventually emailed the operations director at that organization, I didn't have to guess where the pain was. I didn't have to diagnose from the outside. I just had to describe something true and ask if it sounded familiar.

The Mistake I Kept Making

The most persistent failure pattern across my first three months was this: diagnosing a prospect's problems before they told me anything.

It showed up everywhere. In emails. In voicemails. In call openers. I would find something on a website, or hear a detail on a ground-level call, and build a narrative around it. Then I would present that narrative to the decision maker as though I understood their operation.

The emails sounded confident. *"There is often a coordination gap between referral submission and specialist follow-up."* *"Many organizations struggle with loop closure."* *"I may be off base, but it seems like your team is managing a lot of this manually."*

Every one of those sentences has the same problem. They're me telling someone what their world looks like from the outside. That's not empathy. That's projection dressed up as insight.

The fix was a single flip. Instead of *"there is often a coordination gap,"* the sentence becomes *"I'm curious whether the work around it still takes more staff time than it should."* Same content. Different posture. The first one tells. The second one asks.

It sounds like a small adjustment. But in practice it changed every email I wrote. Because once you train yourself to spot the declarative statement and replace it with a genuine question, you realize how much of your outreach was built on assumptions you hadn't earned the right to make.

I also learned to watch for tells in my own writing. *"I may be off base"* means I know I'm reaching. *"No ask here"* signals a hidden agenda. *"Just wanted to put this on your radar"* is a soft pitch pretending not to be one. If I catch those phrases in a draft now, I know the paragraph around them needs to be rethought.

What the Phone Taught Me

About the First Ten Seconds

The first ten seconds of a call decide everything. I learned this by getting it wrong.

Early on, I would open calls by asking a question. *"How are you guys currently handling prior authorizations?"* That works at the coordinator level because you're asking about their daily life. It does not work with a director or COO because you're asking them to describe their operation to a stranger. That's a big ask disguised as a casual question.

I also had a habit of apologizing for calling. *"I know this is kind of out of the blue"* or *"I don't want to take up too much of your time."* Those phrases sound polite. What they actually do is prime the other person to feel uncomfortable. If you frame the call as an imposition, the listener experiences it as one.

The better approach with a decision maker was to lead with an observation instead of a question. *"The thing I keep hearing from referral teams right now is that the follow-up is getting harder to hold together, not because the process is broken but because the people holding it together are stretched thinner than they were a year ago. I don't know if that's true at your organization but I wanted to ask."*

That's an observation followed by a check. It invites the person to be the expert. It doesn't ask them to expose a weakness to a stranger. It gives them something to react to instead of something to compose.

And the most important thing I learned about phone calls was this: the best thing you do on a call is respond to what people actually say. Not what your gameplan says they'll say. Not the next question on your list. What they actually just told you. When a coordinator says *"sounds like a lot's kind of out of your hands at that point,"* and you watch them open up because they felt heard, you realize that listening is not a technique. It is the entire skill.

The Intelligence That Changes Everything

About two months in, I messaged the marketing team. I told them I was on the phone regularly with people inside FQHCs. Referral coordinators, ops leads, decision makers. I was hearing how they talk about their problems, what language they use, what they care about, what they ignore.

My manager's response: *"This is gold. You're really the tip of the spear when understanding what people are saying. Even if they don't ever move to a discovery call, you are having more conversations than anyone."*

That reframed the role for me. The SDR isn't just generating pipeline. The SDR is the only person in the building who talks to the market every single day. That means the SDR carries intelligence that nobody else in the company has access to. The language your prospects use. The workflows they describe. The things that actually frustrate them versus the things the marketing website says should frustrate them.

The people doing referral follow-up don't say "referral leakage." They say *"we just never hear back."* They don't say "care coordination platform." They say *"I have to call the specialist office and sit on hold."* That gap between how we talk about the problem and how they experience it is the most valuable thing the SDR can hand back to the company. If the marketing team is writing copy that sounds like a whitepaper, one real quote from a real coordinator rewires it.

What I Got Wrong About Conference Follow-Up

In late April, my team attended the AAOE orthopedic conference. I wasn't there. Jason and Katie staffed the booth. They handed me a list of contacts who had stopped by, and my job was to follow up.

My first instinct was to make the conference the centerpiece of every email. *"It was great connecting at AAOE." "Following up from our conversation at the conference." "I wanted to continue the discussion from Louisville."*

The problem is that the conference is context, not content. "We met at AAOE" is one sentence of setup. It's not the theme of the email. Every follow-up email still needs at least one sentence that could only be written to that specific person. If you can't write a specific first sentence, you don't have enough information to email them yet.

I also made a mistake on LinkedIn. I sent a connection request to one of the contacts and wrote a note implying I had been at the conference. I wasn't. My team was. The correction was simple: "my team" not "I." But the lesson ran deeper than attribution. If you start the relationship with even a small inaccuracy, you've undermined the honesty that's supposed to be the whole point of your approach.

The Orbits

Not every prospect is ready now. That was one of the hardest things to accept in a role where activity metrics matter every week.

A woman named Lyzette at a community health center in northwest Florida had a warm conversation with me. She was centralized referral operations. Her organization was mid-migration off eClinicalWorks. She told me they weren't in a position to evaluate anything new until after the migration stabilized. That was a Q4 timeline at the earliest.

The old instinct was to push. Find a reason to follow up sooner. Keep the name active. But pushing someone who just told you their building is in the middle of a systems migration doesn't demonstrate persistence. It demonstrates that you weren't listening.

So I calendared it. Q4. And in the meantime, I stayed visible. LinkedIn posts. Occasional relevant shares. No messages. No emails. Just presence.

The follow-up that arrives six to eight weeks later with no automation behind it is often the one that converts. Because it proves you were paying attention, not running a sequence.

What I Would Tell the Next SDR

A second SDR is being hired at Calvient in June. They'll be assigned a different vertical. But they'll inherit the same phones, the same CRM, the same blank slate I started with. If I could hand them one document, it would say this:

Your job is not to pitch. Your job is to understand a world you didn't come from well enough that the people living in it recognize themselves in what you say. That understanding doesn't come from product training or competitor research. It comes from the calls. Hundreds of them. Most will go to voicemail. Some will go badly. A few will teach you something you couldn't learn any other way.

Start at the ground level. Call the people who do the work before you call the people who manage it. You'll learn more in one conversation with a referral coordinator than in a week of LinkedIn research.

Each touch must evolve. Never repeat the same question in different words. If your second email sounds like your first email, you've told the reader you have nothing new to say.

Withhold the ask until you've earned it. The absence of a CTA is the loudest thing in an email. It tells the reader you're not here to take something from them. And it's the thing they'll remember when every other vendor in their inbox is asking for fifteen minutes.

Protect your sources. The coordinator who told you about the spreadsheet workaround, the supervisor who described the three-attempt protocol, the nursing director who said "*the nurse in me can't help but care.*" Those conversations informed your understanding. They are not your talking points. Generalize everything. Let their experience shape your tone, not your pitch deck.

Brevity is respect. Short emails that say one real thing outperform long emails that cover every angle. Telling someone you respect their time takes time. Showing

it means your email is six sentences.

And when you get on the phone, listen. Not strategically. Not to find the pain point. Just listen. The person on the other end of the line will tell you where the pain is if you let them. Your job is to be the person who actually heard it.

Where I Am Now

Three months in, I'm not where the metrics say I should be. My hold-and-show rate is around fifty percent, not the seventy-five percent target. My call connection rate sits at about ten percent. I have accounts in every stage of the pipeline, from hot leads who asked for demos to organizations I won't touch again until the fall.

But I know things about this market that I couldn't have learned any other way. I know what a referral coordinator's queue looks like when she's managing a thousand open cases for three providers. I know what happens when an organization migrates from Athena to eClinicalWorks and their automated fax intake disappears overnight. I know what it sounds like when a nursing director thirty days into the job tells you she doesn't trust that patient self-scheduling will hold across her population, because her patients are different. I know what a director of quality assurance sounds like when she's carrying two roles and won't complain about it because complaining doesn't fix anything.

None of that was in the playbook. All of it was on the phones.

I came into this role with deep sales instincts and zero B2B cold outbound experience. What I've built in three months isn't a perfect pipeline. It's a set of principles tested against real conversations with real people, in a market that punishes inauthenticity and rewards patience.

The calls taught me that. The playbook gave me the structure. But the people on the other end of the line gave me the education.

I'm still learning. I'll be learning for a long time. But I'm no longer calling from the outside trying to get in. I'm calling from a place of genuine understanding, still incomplete, still growing, but honest enough that the people I talk to can hear the difference.

That's what three months on the phones will teach you if you let it.

Bryce Lote

Sales Development Representative, Calvient
May 2026